

PEOPLE CONUNDRUM

India's explosive growth is being driven by its burgeoning SMB sector, which is experiencing revenue increases and double digit growth. This sector constitutes 95 per cent of the industrial units and contributes 40 per cent to the total industrial output of the country and 35 per cent to direct exports. According to the latest statistics, there are about 3.6 million SSI units in India and these employ approximately 19.3 million people, which is second highest next only to agriculture. The success of SMB is very critical not only for the growth of the Indian economy but for unleashing innovation and creativity.

One of the biggest challenges for the SMB sector is the access towards talent. There is risk money flowing into this sector, but talent is not matching the capital flow. It is interesting to note that in spite of various positive factors like growing economy and growing salaries, people still shy away from working in this sector.

The SMB sector needs the best talent. A large number of SMBs are ready to pay high competitive salaries which may have a higher portion of variable pay. In addition, the sector also provides a lot of room to innovate, people are better empowered due to lack of bureaucracy, there exists opportunity to work directly with leaders, and an individual can directly make an impact to the company's growth. All these are the drivers for higher commitment for any individual to give greater performance.

But our obsession with brands has thrown up problems for the SMB sector. There is acceptance in the society only if you work for known brand companies; career growth is about title and company brand but not about learning and experiencing; and career path is moving from an SMB to a larger or branded organisation and not vice versa.

Such behavior is also fueled by talent spotters be it head hunters or HR managers — if you have worked in a branded organisation then you are “good” and a person from an unknown company is really unknown; criteria of success or failure is of the organisation's success and not the learning; there is no appreciation of the challenges in a smaller organisation.

Also people have lot of myths and misgiving about working in SMBs. You may not get five star accommodation when you travel, but it is also not

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roughing out in lodges... there are budget hotels and budget airways. There are functional offices and technology savvy companies. There are professional people to work with who have had much deeper experience of life and understanding the nuances of business and are in spaces which are either unexplored or are niche.

The SMB sector also needs to make talent a high priority and needs to innovate and get access to the best practice of attracting, managing and retaining talent. Leadership at SMB has much bigger role to play in the attraction of talent. People join or work for the purpose, for the leadership, for the idea, and not for the organisation. They need to have a clear and simple message which connects people with the purpose and mission of the organisation. They need to hire for character and not competence. You can teach skills and competence but cannot change the character of a person. You need to hire a person for his hunger, passion and openness to learning and change.

Leaders have to spend more time with their people, build a relationship, solve the talent's day to day problem and act more as a role model. Today a large number of organisations in the SMB sector have become a training ground for the large and mighty — the good talent continues to go with the general trend — join the big boys. SMBs should not see this as a losing battle and should innovate in order to retain talent.

Let us also see how one can manage the downsides or the fear of closure of an SMB. The higher portion of your variable pay can be seen as an investment in a risky market which can pay a much higher return and reduce your exposure to high risk investments, you can ensure you take higher responsibilities, do not go for a fancy title which you are stuck with for all your life and cannot come down and focus on learning and experiencing.

Careers in the SMB sector are not at all a risk from any perspective. It is a learning lab and is relevant in any organisation of any size. These companies create their own niche and a well-run SMB will have its place under the sun even if the biggest of the biggest companies grow. The skills and competencies one develops in working in SMBs can not go wasted and will be leveraged at all times of life. ■

Threat Defence

Maresh Gupta

The year 2007 was characterised by unprecedented innovation and adaptability in the realm of security threats, as criminals once again demonstrated their ability to continually evolve attack strategies to keep ahead of even the most advanced human and technical defences.

Rogue developers create such threats by using worms, viruses, or application-embedded attacks. Botnets can be used to seed an attack, for example, rogue developers can use worms or application-embedded attacks, that is an attack that is hidden within application traffic such as Web traffic or peer-to-peer shared files, to deposit “Trojans”. This combination of attack techniques — a virus or worm used to deposit a Trojan, for example — is relatively new and is known as a blended attack. A blended attack can also occur in phases: an initial attack of a virus with a Trojan that might open up an unsecured port on a computer, disable an access control list (ACL), or disarm antivirus software, with the goal of a more devastating attack to follow soon after.

The evolving perimeter

Changes in network architectures and evolving threats create new security challenges. Also the concept of the network perimeter is changing. In the past, users could only access the network through a few ingress or egress points — usually where the Internet connected to the enterprise network. Enterprises stacked security at the Internet perimeter using firewalls and intrusion detection systems. However today, many more means of gaining entry to the network exist. With the perimeter having been extended and distributed, security too needs to be applied at each of these new ingress and egress points to avoid damaging threats, thus complicating security architectures.

Take for example Virtual Private Networks (VPNs). These allow enterprise users remote access to the corporate network and are much more widely used than just a few years ago. While previously enterprises might have insisted that VPN software run on a specific enterprise-configured computer, today users run VPNs from their own PCs or even from kiosks at copy centres or other businesses. This phenomenon allows many more entryways to the enterprise network and presents a significant challenge to IT departments. Is the computer equipped with virus protection? Are visitors/employees bringing their non-corporate assets into corporate network?

As the network is becoming more vulnerable to attack because of the evolving perimeter, the threats themselves are changing

Or for that matter, let's look at wireless — Wireless LANs (WLANs) pose additional security challenges. Users operating on an unsecured wireless network at a local coffee house may be unaware that a rogue PC, also using the same wireless subnet, is depositing a virus on the PC. When that PC is later docked into the corporate network, the virus/Trojan could gain entry to the network.

Security - the reverse Moore's Law

At the same time, as the network is becoming more vulnerable to attack because of the evolving perimeter, the threats themselves are changing. In addition to Trojans and botnets, newer, even more dangerous threats lurk. Two of the most troublesome are flash threats and self-mutating worms. Flash threats are so named because of the speed with which viruses or worms can spread. In 1999, a virus dubbed “Melissa,” one of the earliest and most widespread viruses at the time, took 16 hours to spread globally, according to Network Associates Inc. In January 2003, the Slammer virus managed to infect more than 90 per cent of the vulnerable hosts worldwide within 10 minutes using a well-known vulnerability in Microsoft's SQL Server. New viruses in the coming months and years are expected to spread even faster. Therefore whatever defences organisations create, they must be able to identify the threat and respond much more quickly than ever before.

The other looming threat is the self-mutating worm. Today's worms are relatively unintelligent. They are programmed to follow a specific set of instructions, such as to infiltrate one machine through a specific port and once on the machine compromise it in some way, for example, causing a buffer overflow and planting a Trojan. If anything interferes with these planned instructions, the worm lacks the ability to adjust and dies. Now, however, rogue developers are adding intelligence and logic to worms so that if they can't complete a specific task worms can mutate and pursue other lines of attack.

Experts call this security dilemma — The Moore's Law in reverse. Whereas Moore's Law postulates that processor performance will double every 18 months while costs will decline dramatically, security is moving in the opposite direction — networks are becoming less secure while the cost to defend them is increasing. This prognosis is supported by Mi2g, a research firm in the UK that specialises in computer security. Mi2g reports that the economic damage from malevolent network security attacks reached somewhere between \$157 billion and \$192 billion worldwide in 2004.